[Kaizen Poker]

Sculpt the perfect deck.

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1. Overview

The game proceeds in rounds, during which players take turns playing actions, and then simultaneously play the best poker hand they can.

The game plays best with 2 players (age 10+), but can scale up to 3 or 4. A typical game lasts 25-35 minutes.

2. Components

The box contains:

- **52 cards**
- **13 chips**

With 52 cards, this is a two-player game, but you can add an additional 52-card deck to play 3 to 4 players.

3. Setup

1. Shuffle all cards and deal 26 to each player; these 26 cards are players' decks. If you have leftover cards (because you have an odd number of players), just set those aside.
2. The player with the best "poker face" goes first. Proceed to the first round...

4. Game Objective

Each round, the player with the best hand wins one of 13 chips. The first player to have an insurmountable chip lead wins.

5. How to Play

Each round consists of four phases

1. **Draw** Each player draws seven cards.
2. **Action** One at a time, each player plays two cards to the table as Actions, resolving them sequentially. Turn order is clockwise.
3. **Score** Once each player has played their Actions, they will be left with exactly five cards in hand. All players reveal their hands simultaneously, and the highest-ranking poker hand wins a chip.
4. **Cleanup** Any cards played as Actions or in a Scoring hand are put in players' discard piles.

If this is your first game, you can play in Introductory Mode to get accustomed to the rhythm of the game. See the section below on Introductory Mode.

6. Details

6.1 Actions

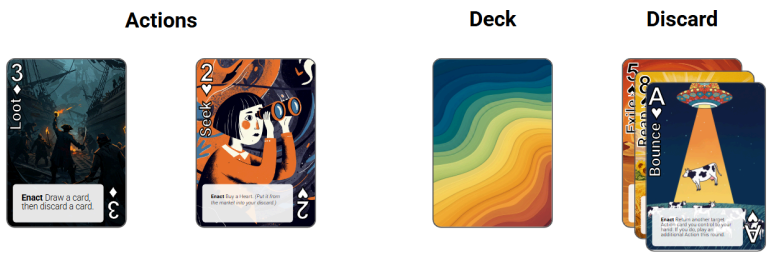
There are several different types of Actions; each plays differently:

- **Enact** Resolve immediately when played
- **React** When in play, resolve when the trigger occurs
- **Modify** When you play your scoring hand, assign one of your scoring cards to any Modify Action you play. The Modify Action changes attributes of that Scoring card.

- **Amend** Changes the rules of the game while in play
- **Remember** No effect when played as an Action, but changes the rules while in the Scrap Pile.
- **Refresh** You can play any card face down as one of your Actions. If you do, you may enact a *Refresh*: Discard a card, then draw a card.

6.2 Layout

I like to put my deck on the right and my discard to the right of that. I play Actions side by side, so they're easy to read. When you play your scoring hand, you just need to reveal your hand, but make it easy to tell which Scoring cards are being altered by any Modify Action you play.



6.3 Vocabulary

- **Scrap** means to take a card from your discard — NOT your hand — and put it in the scrap pile, which is shared between both players.
- **Draw** means to take the top card of your deck into your hand. Eventually, you will need to draw a card while your deck is empty. When that happens, shuffle your discard pile, turn it facedown to make a new deck, and keep drawing as needed.
- **Target** means to specify. Note that if there is nothing to target, the Action cannot be resolved.

7. Ending the Game

There are 13 chips, and the first person to have an insurmountable chip lead (which is 7 in a two-person game) wins!

However! At the start of any round in which a player could win the game, all other players draw eight cards (instead of seven) and play three Actions (instead of two).

If at any time a player has too few cards in their deck (even after reshuffling) to draw a full hand at the start of a round, they lose the game.

8. Themes and clarifications

- The **2s** are all Enact Actions, so as soon as you play one, you may *scrap* a card that matches the specified suits.
- The **3s** give you some card selection, as soon as you play them.
- The **4s** let you find specific cards. Make sure to discard as directed.
- **5♥** lets you return an Action you've already played to your hand (as does A♥).
- The **6s** and **7s** are generally ways to mess with your opponents, or even steal their cards.
- The **8s** and **9s** are mostly different ways to scrap different kinds of cards.
- The **10s** each alter a single card in your scoring hand, allowing you to change the rank or suit of the modified card.
- Some **Js** modify cards in your scoring hand, others enter as copies of other Action cards.
- The **Qs** have no effect if played as Actions, but change the rules of the game for both players as long as they're in the scrap pile.
- The **Ks** all have pretty splashy effects
- The **As** let you "go up a card" and let you play an additional Action.

9. Solo Variant

Shuffle and deal, as normal, two piles of 26. One pile of 26 is your deck. The other deck becomes the Challenger's Deck.

Begin a round, as usual, drawing seven, playing two, and scoring five. When you reveal your scoring hand, flip over the top card of the Challenger's Deck and use the table below to map the rank of the Challenger's card to a hand level:

Challenger's rank	Hand name	Definition
2:	High Card	Highest single card, no other hand achieved
3:	Pair	Two cards of the same rank
4:	Twins	Two cards of the same rank and suit
5:	Two Pair	Two different Pairs
6:	3 of a Kind	Three cards of the same rank
7:	Straight	Five sequentially ranked cards, suits irrelevant
8:	Flush	Five cards of the same suit, ranks irrelevant
9:	Full House	3 of a Kind plus a Pair
10:	4 of a Kind	Four cards of the same rank
J:	Straight Flush	Five sequentially ranked cards of the same suit
Q:	Royal Flush	A Straight Flush consisting of ranks 10, J, Q, K, A
K:	5 of a Kind	Five cards of the same rank
A:	Flush House	A Full House with all cards sharing the same suit
	Flush Five	Five identical cards in both rank and suit

If your hand is better than the Challenger's Hand, you get a chip. Otherwise, the Challenger gets a chip. Ties go to the Challenger. Play rounds until you run out of chips (typically 13 rounds). Your score is the number of chips you win by the end of the game, but anything 7 or better counts as a win.

Note that some of the cards have Abilities that do things to/with the opponent's cards. These aren't going to be much use in a solo game; you might think about ways to remove them from your deck...

10. Introductory Mode

In Introductory Mode, you are attempting to form the best poker hands you can, but you ignore the Action abilities printed on each card. Instead, you spend your Action phase playing cards face down, one at a time, and for each face down card you play, choose one:

— You may draw a card, then discard a card.
— You may scrap a card.

As in the normal game, you draw 7, play 2 Actions, and the remaining 5 cards compose your scoring hand. The only difference in Introductory Mode is that you ignore all Action abilities, and instead play cards face down to draw/discard or scrap.

Once you are comfortable with the rhythm of the game, feel free to start over, using only the Actions printed on the cards.

11. Generative Art Disclaimer

The illustrations used in this prototype were generated through Google's ImageFX web interface. It is not my intent for the final published version to use generative art. I have used it here in lieu of generic clip art, because I had very specific ideas for the art direction of each card.